people's mandate is against us and I humbly accept the verdict. As Congress president, I take responsibility for it,' said Sonia. Rahul echoed the sentiment, but the weak, almost goofy, grin on his face looked inappropriate for the occasion. Neither of them referred to Modi by name. That would happen a few days later. Clearly, some of the bitterness of a long campaign hadn't dissipated.

And yet, watching the images of a victorious Modi saluting the people and a humbled Congress leadership accepting defeat with grace, my mind went back to a meeting I had with the Pakistani prime minister Nawaz Sharif in Jeddah in 2004. Sharif at the time was in exile, living in a rather opulent palace-like structure, having been forced out of the country by General Pervez Musharraf. As we sipped Kashmiri kahwa, Sharif sounded wistful. 'Rajdeepji, your democracy is truly special. One government comes in, another goes but there is no vendetta or bloodletting. Look at us in Pakistan. I am here in Jeddah, Benazir is shuttling between London and Dubai. Neither of us can return home. You are a lucky country!' Indeed, we were. It is a terrible cliché, but the truth is that every Indian election is a constant reminder of the genius of our democracy. 2014 was no different.

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Evening prime time on counting day is usually reserved for the big newsmakers. A little after 9.30 p.m., we had the biggest newsmaker of the day after Modi—Amit Shah. If Modi was the Man of the Series for having successfully driven an unrelenting presidential-style campaign with his charismatic persona, then the effective election micromanaging by Shah made him a deserved Man of the Match. Without the stunning triumph in UP, the BJP would have probably been forced to look for post-poll coalition partners.

Shah had not watched much TV since the morning. When a journalist visited his rented house in Jangpura in south Delhi at 8.30 a.m., he was just waking up. It was only after 9 a.m., when he was certain of which way the